apshabd' (Insults to Narendra Modi by Congress leaders). The document listed twenty-nine such insults. Some of these were recent: Mani Shankar Aiyar calling Modi a 'neech aadmi' (lowly man), Anand Sharma's diatribe on his 'ill mindset', Manish Tiwari and Digvijay Singh's retweet on Modi's birthday of a meme which said '*ise kehte hai choo*** ko bhakt banana or bhakto ko permanent choo**** banana*', Pramod Tiwari's equation of Modi with Hitler and Mussolini, Manish Tiwari likening him to Dawood Ibrahim and Ghulam Nabi Azad calling him 'Gangu teli'.

Others compared Modi to mythological villains, and some of these remarks were from as far back as when he was Gujarat chief minister and not yet a challenger for Delhi. Then Congress general secretary Digvijay Singh, for instance, compared Modi with Rakshas-raj (king of the demons) Ravan and cabinet minister Jairam Ramesh referred to him as 'Bhasmasur', the mythological demon.

Then there were the animal insults. Gujarat Congress leader Arjun Modvadia compared Modi to a monkey with rabies, Salman Khurshid said he attracted people as does an acrobatic monkey, Hussain Dalvai equated him to a chooha (rat) in 2012, Beni Prasad Varma to a mad dog and B.K. Hariprasad to a 'gandi naali ka keeda' (an insect from a dirty drain) in 2009. The oldest insult was Sonia Gandhi's 'maut ka saudagar' (merchant of death) comment, which is said to have turned the 2007 Gujarat election against the Congress.[10]

It is not very often that a political party publishes a list of insults to its top leader in such graphic detail. Even more interestingly, the BJP made no attempt in the press release to counter any of the insults. It did not even comment on them. It went to great lengths to collect these accusations, some over a decade old, and then simply publicised them. The insults themselves were the subliminal message.

A central belief of Modi followers since 2002 has been that he has been unfairly maligned by a lobby of privileged Modi-haters. For this group, any attack on Modi strengthens him. In this view, he is the permanent underdog who pulled himself up by his bootstraps and whose rise the erstwhile elites he ousted from positions of power are unable to stomach. This persona of the genuine 'son of the soil' who